

a different story. Medication meant something was *really* wrong with you. (Ironically, recreationally taking Adderall or Xanax was much more accepted.)

The only public hint I gave to being bipolar was in 2012 when I wrote “What It’s Like to Be Manic,” an article for *Thought Catalog*. I never specified if it was fiction or nonfiction; the site trafficked in both. Even in that article, I purposefully didn’t use the word *bipolar* because I was too scared of the scarlet B of the stigma. I was—and am—terrified of being written off as “crazy.”

For someone who makes a living being transparent about her life on the Internet, I’ve left out a big chunk of my story. So I’ll come clean here: I’m bipolar. For as long as it has taken me to open up about my disorder, it has taken me even longer to connect the dots between my mental health and my finances. Here’s a snippet of the piece I wrote in 2012, explaining my brain on mania:

*Then it’s three hours later and I’ve learned a few phrases in Mandarin and looked up good science graduate programs and bought a book on eBay about musical writing and none of this is actually useful. I’ve just made myself sick with expectations and self-imposed “musts.”*

This includes spending money I didn’t have on whims I didn’t need. I told myself all of these impulsive purchases were “deserved.” There were specific purchases I *needed* to do my best work—for instance, the book on writing musicals. (I never wrote a musical unless you count my unproduced treatment for the rock opera *What’s My Age Again? The Blink 182-sical*. Mark Hoppus, call me.)

The only way I could write my new brilliant novel or my award-winning article idea was if I bought myself a new computer. I’d stay up all night talking myself into filling out graduate school applications for schools in Japan and buying books on Japanese culture.

When I was manic, I wanted to spend all my money because life was a breeze, and who cared about social constructs like money? When I was down, I desperately needed material things to make me feel better. No matter what state I was in, I convinced myself not to look at my finances or try to sort out my bank